

AS TEMPERATURES INCREASE, THE DELICATELY BALANCED SYSTEM FALLS INTO DISARRAY

SPRING CREEP

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Camille Parmesan (1961–)

BEFORE

1997 A group of American scientists publishes evidence of a longer plant growing season at northern high latitudes in 1981–91.

2002 Naturalist Richard Fitter reveals that the first flowering date of 385 plant species in the UK has advanced by 4.5 days in the previous decade.

AFTER

2006 Jonathan Banks, from the American Clean Air Task Force, is the first person to use the term “season creep” to describe the increasingly early onset of the seasons as a result of climate change.

2014 In the US, the National Climate Assessment confirms long-term trends toward shorter, milder winters and earlier spring thaws.

Most scientists now agree that climate change, driven by an increase in greenhouse gases, is raising the global mean temperature. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) cites an increase of 1.98 °F (1.1 °C) since 1880, although in some regions the warming has been even more marked. This warming has affected both plant and animal